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Recent Attempts to Resolve the Escalating Conflict

Prolonged secret efforts by India and Pakistan to develop nuclear weapons reached their dramatic fruition, to the anxious concern of the rest of the world, in May 1998. On 11 May, India triggered three powerful nuclear bombs under the same portion of the Rajasthan desert in which it had first exploded a single bomb twenty-four years earlier.[1] Two more bombs were exploded at the same underground station two days after the first three, sending greater shock waves rumbling through India's desert sands, rattling Pakistan's former capital of Karachi. India's Prime Minister Atul Bihari Vajpayee, whose Hindu-first Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) had just a few months earlier come to power in New Delhi for the first time, exulted over these powerful bomb blasts. Pakistan's Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif, however, remained ominously silent.

Two weeks later, Sharif joyfully announced to the world, "We have paid them back," reporting that five Pakistani nuclear bombs had been successfully exploded under the barren hills of Baluchistan.[2] Indo-Pakistani conflicts thus suddenly escalated from the not inconsiderable dangers of conventional warfare to the terrifying new heights of potential nuclear confrontation, immediately threatening more than a billion South Asians with residual deadly clouds of nuclear pollution, ultimately capable of endangering every life on earth.

President Clinton reacted strongly, freezing all high-tech exports from the United States to both India and Pakistan, as well as any shipments of arms or military spare parts. It was, however, too late. Many of India's scientists felt confident enough to forge ahead with their